

EXAMPLE COMPANY

# Employee Handbook

Version 1.0 | Effective 1 September 2026

**Fictional sample document for Retrieval-Augmented Generation testing.**

This handbook is not legal, HR, or employment advice. It is intentionally structured with distinct policy facts across multiple pages so that document ingestion, semantic retrieval, similarity scoring, page-level citations, and unsupported-question abstention can be tested.

**Document owner:** People & Culture Team

**Applies to:** All UK employees of Example Company

**Review cycle:** Annual

# 1. Employment and Workplace Principles

Example Company aims to provide a professional, inclusive and accountable workplace. Employees are expected to comply with applicable law, internal policies and reasonable management instructions.

## 1.1 Core expectations

- Employees must act with integrity, respect colleagues and customers, and avoid behaviour that could damage the company or its reputation.
- Conflicts of interest must be disclosed promptly to a line manager or the People & Culture Team.
- Confidential business information must only be used for legitimate work purposes.
- Employees must complete all mandatory compliance training by the stated deadline.

## 1.2 Probation and role changes

New permanent employees normally complete a six-month probation period. A role transfer or promotion does not restart probation unless the employment contract specifically states otherwise.

This handbook does not form part of the employment contract unless a section is expressly incorporated into the contract.

## 2. Working Hours and Hybrid Working

### 2.1 Standard working pattern

The standard full-time working week is **37.5 hours**, normally worked Monday to Friday. Core collaboration hours are 10:00 to 15:00 local time, although customer commitments may require different hours.

### 2.2 Hybrid working

Eligible employees may work remotely for up to **three days per week**, subject to team needs, customer commitments, security requirements and line-manager approval. Employees are expected to attend the office or customer site when reasonably requested.

### 2.3 Overseas working

Working from another country requires written approval from People & Culture, Tax and Information Security before travel. Employees must not assume that a personal holiday destination can be used as a temporary work location.

**Remote work is a working arrangement, not an entitlement to permanent home-based employment.**

## 3. Annual Leave and Time Off

### 3.1 Annual leave entitlement

Full-time employees receive **25 days of paid annual leave per holiday year**, in addition to the usual UK public and bank holidays. Part-time employees receive a pro-rated entitlement.

### 3.2 Booking leave

- For planned leave of five working days or more, employees should normally submit the request at least 10 working days in advance.
- Approval depends on operational coverage and is not confirmed until the manager approves the request in the HR system.
- Employees should avoid making non-refundable travel commitments before leave is approved.

### 3.3 Carry-over

Up to **five unused annual-leave days** may normally be carried into the next holiday year with manager approval. Carried-over leave should be used by 31 March unless a statutory exception applies.

**Example: an employee with seven unused days may normally carry over five; the remaining two days would lapse unless an exception has been approved.**

## 4. Sickness Absence and Wellbeing

### 4.1 Reporting sickness

If an employee is unable to work because of illness, they must notify their line manager **by 9:00 a.m. on the first day of absence**, or as soon as reasonably possible in an emergency. A text message should only be used where the manager has agreed that method.

### 4.2 Certification

Employees may self-certify sickness for the first **seven calendar days**. For an absence lasting more than seven calendar days, a fit note or other acceptable medical evidence is required.

### 4.3 Return to work

Managers should hold a brief return-to-work conversation after sickness absence. The purpose is to confirm fitness to return, identify support needs and ensure the absence record is accurate.

The company may refer an employee to Occupational Health where additional workplace support or medical guidance would be helpful.

## 5. Information Security and Acceptable Use

### 5.1 Authentication

Multi-factor authentication is mandatory for all remote access to company systems. Employees must not approve an authentication request they did not initiate.

### 5.2 Passwords

Corporate passwords must be changed at least every **90 days**. Passwords must not be reused across personal and company accounts or shared with colleagues.

### 5.3 Lost or stolen devices

A lost or stolen company laptop, phone, security token or other device must be reported to the IT Service Desk and Information Security **within two hours of discovery**. Employees should provide the last known location and whether the device was logged in.

### 5.4 Software and removable media

- Only approved software may be installed on company-managed devices.
- Unapproved USB storage devices must not be connected to company equipment.
- Security controls, endpoint protection and device encryption must not be disabled.

## 6. Data Protection and Confidentiality

### 6.1 Handling personal data

Personal data must be accessed only where necessary for an authorised business purpose. Employees should use the minimum amount of personal data needed to complete the task.

### 6.2 Data incidents

Any suspected loss, unauthorised disclosure, misdirection or inappropriate access involving personal data must be reported to the Data Protection Officer and Information Security **within one hour of discovery**. Employees must not delay reporting while attempting to investigate the incident themselves.

### 6.3 Storage and sharing

- Company or customer data must not be stored in personal email, personal cloud storage or consumer file-sharing services.
- Sensitive information should only be shared with authorised recipients using approved channels.
- Printed confidential material should be secured when unattended and disposed of through approved confidential-waste facilities.

**Prompt reporting is required even where the employee believes the incident is minor or has already been contained.**

## 7. Business Travel and Expenses

### 7.1 Claim deadlines

Valid business expenses should be submitted through the expense system **within 30 days** of the transaction. Receipts are required unless the expense policy expressly allows an exception.

### 7.2 Hotels

The standard hotel cap is **£150 per night in London** and **£110 per night elsewhere in the UK**, including VAT but excluding breakfast where breakfast is separately itemised. Higher rates require prior approval.

### 7.3 Rail and air travel

Employees should book standard-class rail travel and economy air travel unless an approved exception applies. Travel should be booked through the company travel provider where available.

### 7.4 Meals

Reasonable meal costs may be claimed when an employee is travelling on authorised company business and the meal is not otherwise provided. Alcohol is not reimbursable except where a director has approved a specific client-hosting event in advance.



## 8. Learning, Performance and Career Development

### 8.1 Learning budget

Each permanent employee has a discretionary professional-development budget of up to **£750 per financial year**, subject to manager approval and business relevance. Unused budget does not normally carry forward.

### 8.2 Performance conversations

Employees and line managers should hold a documented performance and development check-in at least **once per quarter**. Objectives should be specific, measurable and linked to role expectations or agreed development goals.

### 8.3 Professional certifications

Exam fees, learning materials and reasonable preparation time may be supported where the certification is aligned to the employee's role or an identified future capability need.

**Completion of a course or certification does not automatically result in promotion or a salary increase.**

## 9. Conduct, Respect at Work and Raising Concerns

### 9.1 Respect at work

Bullying, harassment, victimisation and discrimination are not tolerated. This applies to conduct in the office, at customer sites, during work events and through digital communication channels.

### 9.2 Raising a concern

Employees should normally raise workplace concerns with their line manager or People & Culture. Where that is inappropriate, concerns may be raised with another manager or through the confidential Speak Up channel.

### 9.3 Investigation and confidentiality

Concerns will be handled as confidentially as reasonably possible. Employees are expected to cooperate with authorised investigations and must not retaliate against anyone who raises a concern in good faith.

Knowingly making a false allegation may itself be treated as a conduct matter; an allegation that is not substantiated is not automatically considered false.

# 10. Company Equipment and Home Working

## 10.1 Company equipment

Laptops, phones and other equipment remain company property unless formally transferred in writing. Employees must take reasonable care of equipment and return it when requested or when employment ends.

## 10.2 Home-working equipment

Eligible remote workers may claim up to **£250 once every three years** for approved ergonomic home-working equipment such as a monitor stand, keyboard, mouse or chair accessories. Desks and chairs require separate approval.

## 10.3 Damage and faults

Hardware faults should be reported to the IT Service Desk promptly. Employees should not arrange third-party repairs to company devices without IT approval.

**A security-related loss or theft must follow the two-hour reporting requirement in the Information Security section, not the ordinary hardware-fault process.**

# 11. Emergency Contacts and Policy Administration

## 11.1 Emergency contacts

| Issue                                 | Primary contact                                |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Immediate danger or medical emergency | Emergency services (999)                       |
| Lost/stolen company device            | IT Service Desk + Information Security         |
| Suspected personal-data incident      | Data Protection Officer + Information Security |
| Employment or wellbeing query         | People & Culture                               |
| Ethics or conduct concern             | Line manager / People & Culture / Speak Up     |

## 11.2 Policy changes

Example Company may update non-contractual policies from time to time. Material changes will normally be communicated through the company intranet or another appropriate internal channel.

## 11.3 RAG test note

This fictional handbook intentionally does **not** state the Chief Executive Officer's salary, annual bonus, home address, date of birth, or favourite food. Questions about those topics should therefore be treated as unsupported by this document.

**End of Employee Handbook.**